

Title

Integrated Professional and Peer Support Programs Enhance Exclusive Breastfeeding Continuation in a Middle Eastern Population

Abstract

Low breastfeeding persistence remains a significant public health challenge in the Middle East. Four hundred thirty-three pregnant women were enrolled in early gestation and randomized to either receive an intensive multidisciplinary lactation support intervention or standard antenatal care. The intervention encompassed professional lactation guidance delivered during pregnancy, facility-based support immediately postpartum, and home-based peer mentoring extending through the first six months. Primary outcome assessment at 6 months postpartum showed exclusive breastfeeding rates of 68% in the intervention group versus 42% in the control group ($p = 0.003$, relative risk 1.62). Maternal quality-of-life scores at 1, 3, and 6 months favored the intervention group across multiple domains ($p < 0.01$). Secondary analysis identified cost savings of approximately USD 312 per family through reduced infant illness episodes in the intervention group. These findings support the feasibility and effectiveness of integrating professional expertise with community-level peer support to improve breastfeeding outcomes.